

and distilling it into a picture that truly represents the heart of the average American millionaire. As we did that, five key characteristics rose to the top. These are five attributes that we believe are remarkably consistent across all types of millionaires from all over the country.

By this point, you probably won't be surprised by how simple—even basic—these attributes are. First, average millionaires take *personal responsibility* for their money decisions. They know their success is up to them, and they own it. Second, millionaires *practice intentionality* with their finances, living on less than they make and exercising discipline in their budgeting. Third, typical millionaires are *goal-oriented*. They think ahead and refuse to be swept away by the current of life. Fourth, and not surprisingly, millionaires are *hard workers*. They do what it takes even when what it takes isn't easy. Fifth and last, we found that millionaires know that wealth building takes *consistency*. They know from experience that wealth building is a long-term game, and they've seen that sticking to the plan over decades leads to millions at retirement. These aren't the character traits *I* think can lead to millions; these are the attributes we *found* in the 10,000 millionaires we studied. As we walk through the next several chapters, I'll give you the cold, hard facts about what these men and women believe compared to the general population. And, when you see these five attributes working in high gear, you'll get a clear picture of what financial independence really looks like—and what it could look like for you.

Over the next five chapters, I'm going to unpack each of these attributes for you. I'll show you not only the characteristics that have led to so many millionaire success stories but also the actions to take to get there yourself. By getting to know these millionaires and applying these attributes and actions to your life, you'll be well on your way to writing your own millionaire story someday.